2.2 Defeat of the Spanish Armada

Fans of any sport love a major upset. In much the same way, when England's small but mighty fleet of ships defeated Spain in 1588, the world took notice.

MAIN IDEA Because of England's strong naval fleet, an English victory at sea challenged Spanish dominance in Europe and the Americas.

MONARCHS AND SEA DOGS

Spain had a head start on settling North America, but England started to catch up, largely because of **Queen Elizabeth I**. The Protestant queen ascended to the English throne in 1558. She saw Spain as a threat to England's independence. Her brother-in-law, Philip II of Spain, like many Catholics, wished to see Elizabeth unseated from the throne. He supported Mary, Queen of Scots, Elizabeth's Catholic cousin and the heir to the English throne. But after being implicated in a plot to take Elizabeth's life, Mary was arrested, tried, and beheaded for conspiracy.

Both Philip and Elizabeth had powerful navies. Spain's fleet was made up of large, full-rigged sailing ships called **galleons**, mainly used to transport goods from the Americas. They were heavily armed, but their cannons weren't secured to the deck, which made these large weapons difficult to reload and discharge.

By contrast, English ships were nimble. They carried fewer goods and soldiers, but their mounted artillery was more quickly discharged. English ships were also fast, and their sailors, the **Sea Dogs**, appreciated this quality.

Perhaps the most famous of these sailors was Francis Drake. Drake and other Sea Dogs were **privateers**, or seafarers licensed by a monarch to attack enemy ships. Drake sailed the world stealing treasure from Spanish ports and ships. He and his crew were the first Englishmen to **circumnavigate**, or sail around, the globe.

ENGLISH VICTORY

Under the leadership of Elizabeth I, England challenged Spain's claims to the Western Hemisphere. England supported the Dutch revolt against Philip II. When part of the Netherlands declared its independence from Spain and became the United Provinces in 1585, Elizabeth sent aid there. In doing so, she was essentially declaring war on Spain.

King Philip sent his "invincible" navy to conquer England in May 1588. The **Spanish Armada** was a fleet of about 130 warships. Knowing their vessels



Queen Elizabeth I
In a society where women rarely held any political authority, Elizabeth ruled as a popular, strong, and capable monarch. During the 45 years of her reign, England prospered and became one of the most powerful nations in history. In this portrait, painted around 1588, the English fleet appears behind Elizabeth, likely an acknowledgment of England's increasing naval power.

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were slower and had fewer and smaller cannons than the English, the Spanish captains hoped to take advantage of their own greater numbers. Their plan was to have their men board the enemy ships and defeat the English in hand-to-hand combat.

Stormy weather delayed the armada. This gave English admiral Charles Howard, commander of England's fleet, a chance to join up with Francis Drake's advance force. England's fleet had smaller ships and fewer soldiers, but its superior speed and artillery demolished the Spanish. Many thousands of Spanish men were killed, while England lost several hundred. With only 60 ships remaining, the Spanish returned home in shame.

The defeat of the Spanish Armada was a blow to Spain's position as the dominant world power in both Europe and the New World. Through its victory, England ensured its own continued independence from foreign domination while preserving the Netherlands' United Provinces.

Spain's power weakened further as Sea Dogs continued to harass Spanish vessels and ports. At the same time, Protestant sects in Europe and later in the New World would continue to challenge the supremacy of Spain and the pope on colonization and commerce. Spain found itself on the defensive.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What political changes did England's defeat of the Spanish Armada bring to Europe?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** What were the different advantages and disadvantages of the Spanish and English ships?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did the Spanish captains' strategy to combat the English fleet lead to their own defeat?



CRITICAL VIEWING French artist Philippe-Jacques de Loutherbourg painted *Defeat of the Spanish Armada, 8 August 1588* in 1796. How does the artist use color to show the drama of the battle?

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